Chapter 15 research, second pass: kindness

Researcher desk, 2026-10-23. Full file: `runs/ch15/research-kindness.md`. Nothing is verified. The Stoic wording was read in full from public-domain text. Every study was found by search summary only, because the proxy blocked the journals.

The short answer

Yes, there is good research that kindness is not presence, and yes, there is a Stoic “discipline of kindness.” But three things in the book already collide with it. Those need your ruling.

Kindness is not presence

No study uses the word “kindness.” What predicts a good marriage is **responsiveness**:

she feels understood, valued and cared for. Time in the same room is not the active ingredient. Two studies already in the bundle say so (Reis 2010; Girme 2014).

What fits your material

- **“Take a load off her plate” with a hug:** Gordon and colleagues (2022). Unfair-feeling housework went with lower satisfaction, except when the person felt appreciated. Relief plus recognition is your hug-and-help pair. - **The homecoming scene:** Bodenmann’s *dyadic coping*. Her string of asks is stress communication. Taking over her tasks and “I see you” are named forms of coping. This describes your practice. No study tested your script. - **Motive matters:** Impett and colleagues (2005). Everyday sacrifices made to please a partner went with better days; ones made to end conflict went with worse days. Rolling up your sleeves is kind only if it’s

aimed at her day. - **“Best part of her day” helps you too:** Reis and colleagues (2017). Compassionate acts improved the giver’s day whether noticed or not. The receiver’s benefit depended on noticing. - **Coming home has its own research** (Repetti, Schulz, Saxbe, Campos). One result cuts against the scene: a little decompression for the tired husband may be what a supportive wife gives. The research doesn’t say he must not rest.

Stoic anchors (read in full, unverified)

- **Source of warmth:** Marcus, *Meditations* I.9, on Sextus: “entirely free from passion, and also most affectionate.” The Greek pairs those two words. The second, *philostorgia*, is the word your framework file gives the Sun. It also answers your compassion question. - **Discipline of kindness:** Seneca, *De Beneficiis*

II.1-2: “give willingly, quickly, and without any hesitation,” and “a man gives too late who gives what he has been asked for.” That answers “I shouldn’t have to tell you what to do” from the giver’s side, without blaming her. II.6 adds: don’t reproach while helping; choose another time. - **Tired man:** Marcus VII.74, a play on being tired of receiving what is useful. No Stoic text describes coming home from work. That is a real gap.

Compassion over empathy

The Stoics support “help without being swept up.” Seneca, *On Clemency* II.6: the wise man “will dry the tears of others, but will not mingle his own with them.” But what they reject is **pity**, not empathy. Epictetus, *Discourses* I.11, says fleeing a sick child because you can’t bear it “was not at all an affectionate act.” Safe wording: the Stoics warned against being carried away by

another's suffering and asked for steady, practical help. Chapter 16 is the stronger home for the full distinction.

Collisions you need to rule on

1. **Discipline of action belongs to the Oak.** `05-framework.md` gives it to the Oak. The Sun's anchor is *philostorgia* (Marcus I.9). Calling kindness "the discipline of action" would put an Oak anchor in the Sun chapter. The framework file also labels this chapter's cell "presence as what's owed," which contradicts your "kindness is not presence."
2. **Chapter 12 already owns coffee, wine and breakfast.** Three of your four examples are Chapter 12's romance-as-action. Chapter 15 needs to say what

makes the same act kindness (Seneca: “the spirit in which it is done”), or lead with the others: the foot rub, a chore taken, letting her talk.

3. **Chapter 6 already prints a nearby zing** (“I’m working all the time, and you aren’t”) and Marcus V.1. **Chapter 2** prints the homecoming as stress crossover. Chapter 15’s scene must be different: your response, not her accusation.

Do not claim

No numbers. No “science shows his couch time raises her stress.” No “the Stoics taught compassion over empathy.” Don’t use “where there is a human being there is an opportunity for kindness” (it is about giving money). “If you would be loved, love” is Hecato’s, quoted by Seneca.

What I need from you

1. Discipline of action vs. *philostorgia*: may the Sun chapter lean on Marcus I.9 and leave “discipline of action” to the Oak?
2. Which anchor: Marcus I.9, *De Beneficiis* II.1-2, or both?
3. Which examples are yours, given Chapter 12 owns the coffee, wine and breakfast?
4. Compassion: one line here, or all in Chapter 16?
5. The scene. What did you say back, and what happened?
6. Her seasons: keep or cut?